This was in consonance with the mantra that I had heard repeatedly in the BJP's Lucknow office, as well as among the party's higher echelons. For instance, UP Deputy Chief Minister K.P. Maurya had said that the new BJP started giving 'malik ka darza' (status of owner) to newly appointed booth presidents (as quoted in Chapter 3). A few weeks later, I quizzed several booth- and district-level officials in Mathura about whether this claim rang true to them, in practice. They agreed. 'The BJP has six presidents. The party is standing on the shoulders of a presidential system of *six presidents*,' said one. In Mathura, for example, it was about the 'the booth president, the Mathura nagar president, the district president, the Braj region president (one of six administrative regions in UP in the BJP system), the state president and the national president.'

Crucially, while all these units and functions existed earlier too, the formal institutionalisation of the booth president and the importance given to this rung of the party leadership ladder was an innovation. The importance of the policy should not be underestimated, said one booth president. To put this in perspective, the whole of Mathura district—consisting of five state assembly constituencies and one Lok Sabha seat—had about 2,100 polling booths in 2020.[29] The BJP, after 2014, appointed presidents in each of these booth areas. Suddenly, the city of Mathura was full of party officials with an important-sounding presidential title.

As a BJP city corporator and former booth president in UP told me, 'Whatever you say, if you make a small man a booth president, he says "I am a president" with pride. He will remain at his work. Earlier, we used to have only zila [district] and nagar [city] presidents. There were only two presidents in a city. Whereas now, *adhyakash hee adhyaksh hain* [there are presidents and presidents].'[30]

The party also instituted another practice to encourage the new booth presidents. 'A very good thing happened in this time,' exclaimed the party's Mathura district general secretary, Pradeep Goswami. 'Whatever meetings happen in any area, whether of PM or of sangathan [organisation] president, that area's booth president will be honoured on the stage. This was to develop the booth. Whether it is a small meeting like in a nukkad, this area's booth